

READ TO SPEAK

REAL ENGLISH.
REAL CONNECTIONS.



BRIDGE
Upper-Intermediate

B1+

BRIDGE

Build your fluency.
Bridge ideas.
Speak with **impact**.



Engaging passages on
current and global topics



15 target words with
in-context meanings



Word-tracking grid –
your signature method



Speaking prompts to
share your perspective



Grammar focus drawn
from the passage



by
Ahmed Magdy

READ TO SPEAK

B1+ — Bridge

Upper-Intermediate (lower)

Passages with more nuance and abstract thinking. Topics bridge the personal and the philosophical.

12 units	15 words per unit	240–280 words per passage
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Each unit contains:

- A rich, engaging passage on a meaningful topic
- 15 target words with in-context meanings
- Word-tracking grid, your signature method
- Speaking prompts designed to activate the vocabulary
- Grammar focus drawn directly from the passage
- Review unit every 3 units, recycling vocabulary

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Unit 1 · Self-awareness · The observer within

There is a difference between having a thought and being aware that you are having a thought. Most people experience their thoughts as reality, as absolute statements about the world. 'I am a failure.' 'Nobody cares about me.' 'Things will never get better.' These thoughts arrive with force, and we take them at face value.

Self-awareness is the ability to step back, to observe your thoughts from a slight distance, as if watching clouds pass across a sky. When you practise this, you begin to notice that your thoughts are not facts. They are mental events, often shaped by fatigue, fear, or habit.

The ancient Stoics had a word for this kind of inner observation: *prosoche*, meaning attention to oneself. They believed that most human suffering comes not from events themselves, but from the judgements we make about those events. Change the judgement, and you change the experience.

Developing self-awareness is uncomfortable at first. You begin to see patterns in your behaviour that you would rather not see. But this discomfort is the beginning of change. You cannot alter what you cannot see.

Vocabulary

Word	Part of speech	Meaning in context	Example
awareness	<i>noun</i>	Knowledge or understanding of a situation or fact	<i>Self-awareness leads to growth.</i>
absolute	<i>adjective</i>	Total and unconditional; allowing no exceptions	<i>Don't treat thoughts as absolute truths.</i>
fatigue	<i>noun</i>	Extreme physical or mental tiredness	<i>Fatigue distorts your thinking.</i>
observer	<i>noun</i>	Someone who watches or pays attention	<i>Become the observer of your mind.</i>
prosoche	<i>noun</i>	Stoic concept of paying careful attention to oneself	<i>Prosoche means attending to your inner world.</i>
judgement	<i>noun</i>	An opinion or assessment about something	<i>Suffering comes from our judgements.</i>
patterns	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	Regular and repeated ways of acting or thinking	<i>Notice your patterns of behaviour.</i>
alter	<i>verb</i>	To change something	<i>You can alter your response to events.</i>
uncomfortable	<i>adjective</i>	Making you feel slightly worried or uneasy	<i>Self-awareness is uncomfortable at first.</i>
force	<i>noun</i>	Power, strength; intensity of effect	<i>Thoughts arrive with great force.</i>
suffering	<i>noun</i>	Pain, distress, or hardship	<i>Much suffering comes from our judgements.</i>
ancient	<i>adjective</i>	Very old; belonging to the distant past	<i>Ancient wisdom still applies today.</i>
mental	<i>adjective</i>	Relating to the mind	<i>Thoughts are mental events.</i>

slight	<i>adjective</i>	Small in degree; not large or significant	<i>Step back a slight distance.</i>
rather	<i>adverb</i>	Preferably; more willingly	<i>Patterns we'd rather not see.</i>

Word-tracking grid

Word-tracking grid — how to use it

Each time you use a word in a real conversation, tick one box (☐). Aim for 5 uses before moving on. Do not tick in advance.

Word	Part of speech	1	2	3	4	5	Uses	Example I used it
awareness	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
absolute	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
fatigue	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
observer	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
prosoche	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
judgement	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
patterns	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
alter	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
uncomfortable	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
force	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
suffering	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
ancient	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
mental	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
slight	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
rather	<i>adverb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
Total							_/75	<i>Complete → move to next unit</i>

Speaking prompts

Use these prompts as conversation starters. Try to use as many unit words as possible naturally.

1	Have you ever noticed yourself having a thought and then questioned whether it was true?
2	What is a recurring thought pattern you would like to change?
3	Do you think most of our suffering comes from events or from our reactions to them?
4	How do you practise self-awareness in your daily life?

Grammar focus

As if / as though — making comparisons

'As if' and 'as though' are used to describe how something seems or feels by comparing it to something else: 'as if watching clouds pass across a sky'. They are followed by a clause.

Examples from the passage context:

- She observed her thoughts as if watching a film.
- He spoke as though nothing had happened.
- It felt as if time had stopped.
- She listened as if she already knew the answer.

Practice task:

Write 3 sentences using 'as if' or 'as though' to describe how something felt or appeared.

Write your answers here:

Unit 2 · Integrity · The gap between values and actions

Most people have a set of values they would describe as central to who they are, honesty, kindness, fairness, courage. And yet, if you observed their behaviour across an average week, you would often find a gap between those stated values and how they actually behave.

This gap is not necessarily a sign of hypocrisy. It is usually a sign of the enormous pressure that everyday life puts on us. We intend to be patient, but we are tired. We intend to be honest, but the truth feels risky. We intend to be kind, but we are distracted.

Integrity is not a fixed character trait you either have or don't have. It is a daily practice of closing the gap, of noticing when your actions have drifted from your values, and realigning them without excessive self-judgement.

The philosopher Aristotle argued that character is built through repeated action. You do not become brave by thinking about courage, you become brave by repeatedly doing courageous things. Integrity works the same way. Each time you act in accordance with your values, especially when it is inconvenient to do so, you strengthen the connection between who you say you are and who you actually are.

Vocabulary

Word	Part of speech	Meaning in context	Example
integrity	<i>noun</i>	The quality of being honest and having strong moral principles	<i>She acted with great integrity.</i>
hypocrisy	<i>noun</i>	Claiming beliefs you don't actually practise	<i>Integrity prevents hypocrisy.</i>
intend	<i>verb</i>	To plan or mean to do something	<i>I intend to be more patient.</i>
drifted	<i>verb (past)</i>	Moved gradually away from a position or standard	<i>His actions drifted from his values.</i>
realigning	<i>verb</i>	Adjusting to bring back into the correct position	<i>She focused on realigning her behaviour.</i>
excessive	<i>adjective</i>	More than what is necessary or reasonable	<i>Avoid excessive self-criticism.</i>
trait	<i>noun</i>	A characteristic feature of someone's personality	<i>Integrity is a core character trait.</i>
Aristotle	<i>noun (proper)</i>	Ancient Greek philosopher who wrote about virtue and character	<i>Aristotle believed character is built by action.</i>
accordance	<i>noun</i>	Agreement with a rule or standard	<i>Act in accordance with your values.</i>
inconvenient	<i>adjective</i>	Causing difficulty or effort	<i>Honesty is sometimes inconvenient.</i>
strengthen	<i>verb</i>	To make stronger	<i>Each act of integrity strengthens character.</i>

stated	<i>adjective</i>	Expressed or declared openly	<i>Your stated values and real actions may differ.</i>
courageous	<i>adjective</i>	Having or showing courage	<i>She made a courageous decision.</i>
enormous	<i>adjective</i>	Very large in size or degree	<i>Life puts enormous pressure on us.</i>
closing	<i>verb</i>	Reducing or eliminating a gap or difference	<i>Closing the gap takes daily effort.</i>

Word-tracking grid

Word-tracking grid — how to use it

Each time you use a word in a real conversation, tick one box (☐). Aim for 5 uses before moving on. Do not tick in advance.

Word	Part of speech	1	2	3	4	5	Uses	Example I used it
integrity	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
hypocrisy	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
intend	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
drifted	<i>verb (past)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
realigning	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
excessive	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
trait	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
Aristotle	<i>noun (proper)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
accordance	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
inconvenient	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
strengthen	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
stated	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
courageous	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
enormous	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
closing	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
Total							_/75	<i>Complete → move to next unit</i>

Speaking prompts

Use these prompts as conversation starters. Try to use as many unit words as possible naturally.

1 What are your core values? Do your actions always match them?

- 2 Can you think of a time when you acted against your own values? How did it feel?
- 3 Do you think integrity is something you have or something you practise?
- 4 How do you respond when someone else acts in a way that conflicts with their stated values?

Grammar focus

Either ... or / Neither ... nor

We use 'either ... or' for positive alternatives and 'neither ... nor' for negative alternatives: 'a trait you either have or don't have'. These structures connect two parallel choices.

Examples from the passage context:

- You either act on your values or you don't.
- Neither excuses nor intentions build character.
- It is either a habit or it is not.
- Neither fatigue nor pressure justifies dishonesty.

Practice task:

Write 3 sentences using 'either ... or' or 'neither ... nor' about integrity, habits, or character.

Write your answers here:

Unit 3 · Stoicism · What you can and cannot control

The ancient Stoic philosophers, Epictetus, Marcus Aurelius, Seneca, lived very different lives, but they shared a central conviction: that the key to a good life is understanding the difference between what is within your control and what is not.

Epictetus, who was born into slavery, argued that although he could not control his physical circumstances, he always had complete control over his responses. No one could take his mind from him. This distinction, between the external world and the internal one, is the foundation of Stoic philosophy.

In practice, this means focusing your energy on your own actions, choices, and interpretations, rather than spending it trying to change or control things that are beyond you: other people's opinions, the outcome of events, or the passage of time.

This is harder than it sounds. We are wired to react to external events, to feel disturbed by criticism, and to be frustrated by things that do not go our way. The Stoic practice is to notice this reaction, to pause, and to ask: is this within my control? If not, release it. If yes, act on it.

Vocabulary

Word	Part of speech	Meaning in context	Example
conviction	<i>noun</i>	A firmly held belief	<i>He spoke with deep conviction.</i>
circumstances	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	The conditions or facts surrounding a situation	<i>External circumstances change.</i>
distinction	<i>noun</i>	A clear difference between two things	<i>The Stoics made a clear distinction.</i>
foundation	<i>noun</i>	The basic principle or structure something is built on	<i>Trust is the foundation of a relationship.</i>
interpretations	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	Explanations or understandings of something	<i>Our interpretations shape our reality.</i>
wired	<i>adjective</i>	Naturally programmed to behave in a certain way	<i>We are wired to seek approval.</i>
disturbed	<i>adjective</i>	Upset or troubled by something	<i>He wasn't disturbed by criticism.</i>
criticism	<i>noun</i>	The expression of disapproval about something	<i>Handle criticism with grace.</i>
release	<i>verb</i>	To let go of something you have been holding onto	<i>Learn to release what you cannot control.</i>
pause	<i>verb</i>	To stop briefly before continuing	<i>Pause before you react.</i>
external	<i>adjective</i>	Coming from outside; not from within	<i>External events cannot control you.</i>
internal	<i>adjective</i>	Coming from within; relating to the mind or inner world	<i>Focus on your internal response.</i>

passage	<i>noun</i>	The process of time moving forward	<i>The passage of time heals pain.</i>
slavery	<i>noun</i>	The system of people being owned by others	<i>Epictetus was born into slavery.</i>
outcome	<i>noun</i>	The final result of a process or event	<i>You can't always control the outcome.</i>

Word-tracking grid

Word-tracking grid — how to use it

Each time you use a word in a real conversation, tick one box (☐). Aim for 5 uses before moving on. Do not tick in advance.

Word	Part of speech	1	2	3	4	5	Uses	Example I used it
conviction	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
circumstances	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
distinction	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
foundation	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
interpretations	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
wired	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
disturbed	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
criticism	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
release	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
pause	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
external	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
internal	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
passage	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
slavery	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
outcome	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
Total							_/75	<i>Complete → move to next unit</i>

Speaking prompts

Use these prompts as conversation starters. Try to use as many unit words as possible naturally.

1	What things in your life do you spend energy on that you cannot control?
2	How do you apply the idea of 'what I can and cannot control' in your own life?

3 Do you think it is possible to have complete control over your responses to events?

4 Which Stoic idea do you find most useful? Why?

Grammar focus

Although / Even though / Despite — concession

'Although' and 'even though' introduce a clause. 'Despite' and 'in spite of' are followed by a noun or -ing form. All express concession, the idea that something is true despite another thing.

Examples from the passage context:

- Although he was a slave, he was free in his mind.
- Even though life was hard, she stayed composed.
- Despite the criticism, he held to his values.
- In spite of failure, they kept going.

Practice task:

Write 3 sentences using 'although', 'even though', or 'despite' about control, resilience, or values.

Write your answers here:

Review Unit 1

Recycling vocabulary from Unit 1, Unit 2, Unit 3

Mixed tracking grid

Use each word in a new sentence you write yourself. Tick a box each time you use it in conversation.

Word	1	2	3	4	5	Sentence using the word
awareness	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
observer	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
patterns	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
force	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
mental	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
integrity	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
drifted	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
trait	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
inconvenient	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
courageous	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
conviction	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
foundation	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
disturbed	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
pause	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
passage	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	

Cumulative speaking challenge

Use at least 8 of the review words in a single conversation on any topic. Try to connect the words naturally, don't just list them.

Words I used:

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

6.

7.

8.

Self-assessment:

How naturally did you use the words?

☐ Very naturally
 ☐ Mostly well
 ☐ Needs more practice

Notes:

Unit 4 · Creativity · Where ideas come from

There is a common myth that creative people are born different, that inspiration strikes them like lightning, fully formed. The reality is considerably less dramatic and considerably more interesting.

Most creative insights, in art, science, business, or everyday problem-solving, come not from sudden flashes of brilliance, but from a process of sustained attention, exposure to diverse ideas, and a willingness to tolerate confusion for long enough that a new connection can form.

The writer Austin Kleon describes creative work as 'stealing like an artist', taking influences from a wide range of sources and recombining them in new ways. This is not plagiarism. It is how creativity works. Nothing is entirely original. Everything builds on what came before.

The practical implication is that you cannot wait for inspiration. You have to show up and do the work, even when you feel uninspired. Most professional creatives describe their experience not as a flow of constant inspiration, but as a discipline, the discipline of sitting down and starting, even badly, and trusting that the work will find its shape.

Vocabulary

Word	Part of speech	Meaning in context	Example
myth	<i>noun</i>	A widely believed but false idea	<i>It's a myth that creativity is rare.</i>
inspiration	<i>noun</i>	A feeling of enthusiasm and new ideas	<i>Inspiration comes from unlikely places.</i>
considerably	<i>adverb</i>	By a large amount; notably	<i>The result was considerably better.</i>
sustained	<i>adjective</i>	Maintained for a long period without stopping	<i>Creativity requires sustained attention.</i>
exposure	<i>noun</i>	The experience of encountering something new	<i>Exposure to different ideas helps creativity.</i>
diverse	<i>adjective</i>	Showing a great deal of variety	<i>Read diverse books and subjects.</i>
tolerate	<i>verb</i>	To accept something difficult without complaining	<i>You must tolerate confusion to be creative.</i>
confusion	<i>noun</i>	The state of not understanding something clearly	<i>Confusion often precedes insight.</i>
insights	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	Deep or sudden understandings of something	<i>Creative insights take time.</i>
plagiarism	<i>noun</i>	Copying someone else's work and claiming it as your own	<i>Inspiration is not plagiarism.</i>
implication	<i>noun</i>	A conclusion that follows from something, though not directly stated	<i>What are the implications of this?</i>
uninspired	<i>adjective</i>	Lacking motivation, energy, or new ideas	<i>Work even when you feel uninspired.</i>

discipline	<i>noun</i>	Training yourself to follow rules and routines consistently	<i>Creativity is a discipline.</i>
recombining	<i>verb</i>	Putting things together in a new way	<i>Artists work by recombining influences.</i>
brilliance	<i>noun</i>	Exceptional intelligence or talent	<i>Flashes of brilliance are rare.</i>

Word-tracking grid

Word-tracking grid, how to use it

Each time you use a word in a real conversation, tick one box (☐). Aim for 5 uses before moving on. Do not tick in advance.

Word	Part of speech	1	2	3	4	5	Uses	Example I used it
myth	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
inspiration	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
considerably	<i>adverb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
sustained	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
exposure	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
diverse	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
tolerate	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
confusion	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
insights	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
plagiarism	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
implication	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
uninspired	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
discipline	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
recombining	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
brilliance	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
Total							_/75	<i>Complete → move to next unit</i>

Speaking prompts

Use these prompts as conversation starters. Try to use as many unit words as possible naturally.

1	Do you think of yourself as creative? Where do your best ideas come from?
2	Have you ever had a creative breakthrough after a period of confusion or struggle?

3 What influences your thinking the most, books, music, people, experiences?

4 How do you keep working when you feel uninspired?

Grammar focus

Come from / build on / find shape, metaphorical verbs

English uses many verbs metaphorically. In the passage: 'inspiration strikes', 'work finds its shape', 'ideas come from'. Understanding these metaphorical usages makes your English feel more natural and sophisticated.

Examples from the passage context:

- Ideas rarely arrive fully formed.
- The plan began to take shape.
- Her confidence grew from experience.
- The argument falls apart under scrutiny.

Practice task:

Write 3 sentences using metaphorical verbs (take shape, grow from, build on, fall apart) about creativity or learning.

Write your answers here:

Unit 5 · Regret · The weight of might have been

Regret is one of the most uncomfortable emotions to sit with. Unlike sadness, which is a response to something that has happened, regret is a response to something you feel you caused, a choice you made, or failed to make, that led to a different and worse outcome.

Psychologists distinguish between two types of regret: regret of action, things you did and wish you hadn't, and regret of inaction, things you didn't do and wish you had. Research consistently finds that in the long run, people regret the things they didn't do far more than the things they did.

This suggests something important about how to live. The fear of failure, the fear of judgement, the fear of trying and not succeeding, these fears are less costly than the long, slow ache of a life unlived.

But regret can also be constructive. When we examine our regrets honestly, they often reveal what we truly value. If you regret not spending more time with your family, that regret is pointing you towards what matters. The question is whether you will use it as information, to redirect your choices, or simply use it as another reason to feel bad about yourself.

Vocabulary

Word	Part of speech	Meaning in context	Example
regret	<i>noun/verb</i>	A feeling of sadness about something you did or didn't do	<i>I regret not taking that opportunity.</i>
distinguish	<i>verb</i>	To recognise or show the difference between things	<i>Can you distinguish between the two?</i>
inaction	<i>noun</i>	Failure to take action when action was needed	<i>Regret of inaction is the deepest.</i>
consistently	<i>adverb</i>	In a regular, repeated, and reliable way	<i>Research consistently finds this.</i>
costly	<i>adjective</i>	Involving great loss or sacrifice	<i>Fear of failure is costly.</i>
ache	<i>noun</i>	A continuous dull pain or longing	<i>The ache of a life unlived.</i>
constructive	<i>adjective</i>	Useful and intended to improve things	<i>Use regret in a constructive way.</i>
examine	<i>verb</i>	To look at something carefully and in detail	<i>Examine your regrets honestly.</i>
reveal	<i>verb</i>	To make something known that was hidden	<i>Regrets reveal what we value.</i>
redirect	<i>verb</i>	To change the direction or focus of something	<i>Redirect your energy toward what matters.</i>
unlived	<i>adjective</i>	Not fully experienced or taken advantage of	<i>She feared a life unlived.</i>
outcome	<i>noun</i>	The result or consequence of an action or event	<i>Choices lead to different outcomes.</i>

caused	<i>verb (past)</i>	Made something happen	<i>She felt she had caused the problem.</i>
ache	<i>noun</i>	A dull, persistent feeling of longing or pain	<i>He felt the ache of missed opportunity.</i>
suggest	<i>verb</i>	To indicate or imply something indirectly	<i>This suggests a different approach.</i>

Word-tracking grid

Word-tracking grid, how to use it

Each time you use a word in a real conversation, tick one box (☐). Aim for 5 uses before moving on. Do not tick in advance.

Word	Part of speech	1	2	3	4	5	Uses	Example I used it
regret	<i>noun/verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
distinguish	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
inaction	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
consistently	<i>adverb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
costly	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
ache	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
constructive	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
examine	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
reveal	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
redirect	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
unlived	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
outcome	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
caused	<i>verb (past)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
ache	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
suggest	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
Total							_/75	<i>Complete → move to next unit</i>

Speaking prompts

Use these prompts as conversation starters. Try to use as many unit words as possible naturally.

1	What is your biggest regret of action? What is your biggest regret of inaction?
2	Do you agree that people regret what they didn't do more than what they did?

3 How do you use regret constructively rather than destructively?

4 Is there a regret that has taught you something important?

Grammar focus

Third conditional, imagining different pasts

We use the third conditional to talk about things in the past that didn't happen: 'If I had tried, I would have succeeded.' It's formed with: if + past perfect, would + have + past participle.

Examples from the passage context:

- If I had spoken up, things would have been different.
- She wouldn't have regretted it if she had tried.
- If he had taken the opportunity, his life would have changed.
- I would have stayed if I had known.

Practice task:

Write 3 third conditional sentences about decisions or missed opportunities in your own life.

Write your answers here:

Unit 6 · Vulnerability · The strength in being seen

Vulnerability is widely misunderstood. It is often associated with weakness, the exposure of something soft or fragile that should be protected. But vulnerability is not weakness. It is the willingness to be seen, to show what you genuinely think and feel, without certainty about how it will be received.

The researcher Brené Brown spent years studying human connection and found that vulnerability is actually the birthplace of creativity, love, belonging, and joy. People who avoid vulnerability, who protect themselves at all costs, also end up cutting themselves off from the very things that make life meaningful.

Vulnerability requires courage. It takes courage to say 'I love you' first. It takes courage to admit that you do not know the answer. It takes courage to start something without knowing whether it will succeed. These are not acts of weakness. They are acts of extraordinary bravery.

The paradox is this: the more you try to appear invulnerable, the less real you become to others, and to yourself. Genuine connection, the kind that actually sustains us, can only form where there is authentic vulnerability.

Vocabulary

Word	Part of speech	Meaning in context	Example
vulnerability	<i>noun</i>	The quality of being exposed to harm or criticism; openness	<i>Vulnerability builds connection.</i>
exposure	<i>noun</i>	The state of being open to something, including judgement	<i>Emotional exposure takes courage.</i>
fragile	<i>adjective</i>	Easily broken or damaged; delicate	<i>She felt fragile after the loss.</i>
genuine	<i>adjective</i>	Truly what it seems; not artificial or pretended	<i>Speak with genuine emotion.</i>
certainty	<i>noun</i>	The quality of being sure or definite	<i>Act without certainty of the result.</i>
birthplace	<i>noun</i>	The place or condition where something first begins	<i>Vulnerability is the birthplace of love.</i>
belonging	<i>noun</i>	The feeling of being accepted and part of a group	<i>We all need a sense of belonging.</i>
invulnerable	<i>adjective</i>	Appearing impossible to harm or affect	<i>Nobody is truly invulnerable.</i>
authentic	<i>adjective</i>	Real and genuine; not a copy or pretence	<i>Be authentic in your relationships.</i>
sustains	<i>verb</i>	Keeps something going over time	<i>Connection sustains us.</i>
extraordinary	<i>adjective</i>	Very unusual and impressive	<i>She showed extraordinary courage.</i>
paradox	<i>noun</i>	A statement that seems contradictory but is true	<i>There is a paradox in vulnerability.</i>
misunderstood	<i>verb (past p.)</i>	Incorrectly interpreted or perceived	<i>Vulnerability is widely misunderstood.</i>

protect	<i>verb</i>	To keep something safe from harm	<i>We protect ourselves from pain.</i>
associated	<i>verb (past p.)</i>	Connected or linked in the mind with something	<i>Vulnerability is associated with weakness.</i>

Word-tracking grid

Word-tracking grid, how to use it

Each time you use a word in a real conversation, tick one box (☐). Aim for 5 uses before moving on. Do not tick in advance.

Word	Part of speech	1	2	3	4	5	Uses	Example I used it
vulnerability	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
exposure	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
fragile	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
genuine	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
certainty	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
birthplace	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
belonging	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
invulnerable	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
authentic	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
sustains	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
extraordinary	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
paradox	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
misunderstood	<i>verb (past p.)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
protect	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
associated	<i>verb (past p.)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
Total							_/75	<i>Complete → move to next unit</i>

Speaking prompts

Use these prompts as conversation starters. Try to use as many unit words as possible naturally.

1	Do you find it easy or difficult to be vulnerable with people? Why?
2	Can you think of a time when showing vulnerability led to something positive?
3	Do you think society encourages or discourages vulnerability? Give examples.

4 What does 'being seen' mean to you?

Grammar focus

The ... the ... comparative, parallel comparatives

The structure 'the more ... the more / the less' shows that two things increase or decrease together: 'the more you try to appear invulnerable, the less real you become'. This is a sophisticated pattern.

Examples from the passage context:

- The more vulnerable you are, the deeper the connection.
- The less you judge, the more others open up.
- The more honest you are, the more you respect yourself.
- The harder you try to hide, the more isolated you feel.

Practice task:

Write 3 sentences using the 'the more ... the more/less' structure about relationships, habits, or growth.

Write your answers here:

Review Unit 2

Recycling vocabulary from Unit 4, Unit 5, Unit 6

Mixed tracking grid

Use each word in a new sentence you write yourself. Tick a box each time you use it in conversation.

Word	1	2	3	4	5	Sentence using the word
myth	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
sustained	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
tolerate	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
plagiarism	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
discipline	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
regret	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
consistently	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
constructive	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
redirect	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
caused	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
vulnerability	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
genuine	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
belonging	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
sustains	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
misunderstood	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	

Cumulative speaking challenge

Use at least 8 of the review words in a single conversation on any topic. Try to connect the words naturally, don't just list them.

Words I used:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

5. _____

6. _____

7. _____

8. _____

Self-assessment:

How naturally did you use the words?

☐ Very naturally ☐ Mostly well ☐ Needs more practice

Notes:

Unit 7 · Forgiveness · Letting go of the weight

Forgiveness is one of the most misunderstood concepts in human experience. Many people believe that to forgive is to excuse, to say that what happened was acceptable. It is not. Forgiveness does not mean approval. It means releasing yourself from the ongoing burden of resentment.

When we hold on to anger or resentment, we believe we are protecting ourselves. In reality, resentment is like carrying a heavy stone everywhere you go. It does not harm the person who hurt you, it harms you. The weight is yours to carry.

Researchers have found that forgiveness is associated with lower levels of anxiety, depression, and physical stress. People who forgive tend to have better cardiovascular health and stronger immune systems. Forgiveness is, among other things, a health decision.

But forgiveness is not simple, and it is rarely fast. It is a process, sometimes a long one, of choosing, repeatedly, to release resentment rather than feed it. It does not require you to trust the person who hurt you again. It does not require any interaction with them at all. Forgiveness is something you do for yourself, in the quiet of your own mind.

Vocabulary

Word	Part of speech	Meaning in context	Example
forgiveness	<i>noun</i>	The act of letting go of resentment towards someone	<i>Forgiveness is an act of self-care.</i>
excuse	<i>verb</i>	To justify or overlook a wrong action	<i>To forgive is not to excuse.</i>
approval	<i>noun</i>	Agreement that something is acceptable or right	<i>Forgiveness does not mean approval.</i>
burden	<i>noun</i>	A heavy load, physically or emotionally	<i>Resentment is a heavy burden.</i>
resentment	<i>noun</i>	Anger and bitterness felt towards someone who hurt you	<i>Release your resentment.</i>
cardiovascular	<i>adjective</i>	Relating to the heart and blood vessels	<i>Forgiveness improves cardiovascular health.</i>
immune	<i>adjective</i>	Protected from or resistant to something	<i>A strong immune system resists disease.</i>
interaction	<i>noun</i>	Communication or direct involvement with someone	<i>You don't need interaction to forgive.</i>
repeatedly	<i>adverb</i>	Many times; again and again	<i>You must choose to forgive repeatedly.</i>
releasing	<i>verb</i>	Letting go of something you have been holding	<i>Releasing resentment takes courage.</i>
depression	<i>noun</i>	A mental state of persistent sadness and hopelessness	<i>Resentment can cause depression.</i>
anxiety	<i>noun</i>	Persistent worry and nervousness	<i>Forgiveness reduces anxiety.</i>

ongoing	<i>adjective</i>	Continuing; still happening	<i>Resentment is an ongoing weight.</i>
associated	<i>adjective</i>	Connected or linked to something	<i>Forgiveness is associated with better health.</i>
concept	<i>noun</i>	An idea or principle	<i>Forgiveness is a complex concept.</i>

Word-tracking grid

Word-tracking grid, how to use it

Each time you use a word in a real conversation, tick one box (☐). Aim for 5 uses before moving on. Do not tick in advance.

Word	Part of speech	1	2	3	4	5	Uses	Example I used it
forgiveness	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
excuse	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
approval	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
burden	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
resentment	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
cardiovascular	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
immune	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
interaction	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
repeatedly	<i>adverb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
releasing	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
depression	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
anxiety	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
ongoing	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
associated	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
concept	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
Total							_/75	<i>Complete → move to next unit</i>

Speaking prompts

Use these prompts as conversation starters. Try to use as many unit words as possible naturally.

1	Have you ever forgiven someone for something serious? What was that process like?
2	Do you agree that forgiveness is something you do for yourself, not for the other person?
3	Is there something you find it hard to forgive, in others or in yourself?

Grammar focus

It does not require ..., formal negative structures

In formal and written English, we often use 'it does not require', 'it does not mean', rather than 'it doesn't'. The passage uses this throughout to build a logical argument. This is also called formal register.

Examples from the passage context:

- It does not mean you approve.
- It does not require trust.
- Forgiveness does not eliminate the past.
- It does not involve forgetting what happened.

Practice task:

Write 3 formal sentences clarifying what forgiveness, courage, or integrity does NOT mean or require.

Write your answers here:

Unit 8 · Failure · The hidden teacher

Every culture says it values failure as a teacher. And yet, the same cultures create school systems, workplaces, and social environments in which failure is penalised, hidden, or treated as evidence of character flaws rather than as an inherent part of any ambitious undertaking.

The result is that most people go to considerable lengths to avoid failure, even when avoidance means never trying anything genuinely difficult. This creates a particular kind of sadness: a life that is comfortable but small.

Failure teaches things that success cannot. It shows you where your plan had flaws. It reveals what you genuinely want versus what you thought you wanted. And it builds a kind of confidence that cannot be built any other way, the knowledge that you have survived something hard.

This does not mean pursuing failure for its own sake. It means being willing to enter the arena of risk, where failure is a genuine possibility. As Theodore Roosevelt said, it is not the critic who counts, it is the person in the arena, face covered in dust and sweat and blood, who strives valiantly and sometimes fails, but who is never among those cold and timid souls who know neither victory nor defeat.

Vocabulary

Word	Part of speech	Meaning in context	Example
penalised	<i>verb (past p.)</i>	Punished for a mistake or failure	<i>Failure should not be penalised.</i>
inherent	<i>adjective</i>	A natural and permanent part of something	<i>Risk is inherent in any bold venture.</i>
undertaking	<i>noun</i>	A large or difficult task or project	<i>Learning a language is a serious undertaking.</i>
avoidance	<i>noun</i>	The act of staying away from something	<i>Avoidance prevents growth.</i>
flaws	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	Weaknesses or imperfections in something	<i>The plan had serious flaws.</i>
arena	<i>noun</i>	A place of competition or difficult action	<i>Enter the arena of risk.</i>
valiantly	<i>adverb</i>	In a brave and determined way	<i>She strived valiantly.</i>
timid	<i>adjective</i>	Lacking courage or confidence	<i>Don't be timid, try.</i>
strives	<i>verb</i>	Makes great efforts to achieve something	<i>She strives to improve every day.</i>
considerable	<i>adjective</i>	Large in size, extent, or significance	<i>She went to considerable lengths.</i>
evidence	<i>noun</i>	Information showing whether something is true	<i>Failure is not evidence of weakness.</i>
character	<i>noun</i>	The mental and moral qualities of a person	<i>Failure reveals character.</i>

ambitious	<i>adjective</i>	Having a strong desire to achieve something difficult	<i>Only ambitious people risk failure.</i>
genuine	<i>adjective</i>	Real; not pretended or exaggerated	<i>Feel genuine emotions, not performed ones.</i>
critic	<i>noun</i>	A person who expresses disapproval or judgement	<i>Don't listen to the critic, act.</i>

Word-tracking grid

Word-tracking grid, how to use it

Each time you use a word in a real conversation, tick one box (□). Aim for 5 uses before moving on. Do not tick in advance.

Word	Part of speech	1	2	3	4	5	Uses	Example I used it
penalised	<i>verb (past p.)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
inherent	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
undertaking	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
avoidance	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
flaws	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
arena	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
valiantly	<i>adverb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
timid	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
strives	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
considerable	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
evidence	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
character	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
ambitious	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
genuine	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
critic	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
Total							_/75	<i>Complete → move to next unit</i>

Speaking prompts

Use these prompts as conversation starters. Try to use as many unit words as possible naturally.

1	Tell me about a failure that taught you something important.
2	Do you think your school or workplace genuinely values failure as a learning tool?

3 What is the difference between a life that is comfortable and one that is meaningful?

4 What would you try if you knew you could not fail?

Grammar focus

Rather than, expressing preference or contrast

'Rather than' is used to show that one thing is preferred or chosen over another: 'never trying anything difficult rather than risking failure'. It can be followed by -ing or a noun.

Examples from the passage context:

- He chose safety rather than risk.
- Rather than avoiding failure, embrace it.
- She stayed silent rather than speaking her truth.
- Rather than blaming others, take responsibility.

Practice task:

Write 3 sentences using 'rather than' about choices you make or attitudes you value.

Write your answers here:

Unit 9 · Empathy · Walking in someone else's world

Empathy is often confused with sympathy. Sympathy is feeling sorry for someone, looking at their pain from the outside. Empathy is something more demanding: it requires you to enter another person's experience, to feel with them rather than simply for them.

This is harder than it sounds. Every person's internal world is different from yours. Their fears, their history, their sense of what is shameful or embarrassing, all of this is shaped by experiences you may have no knowledge of. To be truly empathetic is to hold that complexity without reducing the other person to a simple narrative.

Rogers and Farson, who developed the concept of active listening, argued that most people respond to others' problems by giving advice, reassurance, or analysis, anything but genuine understanding. Real empathy requires suspending your own perspective and genuinely trying to experience the world as the other person does.

The practical benefit is remarkable. When people feel genuinely understood, they become less defensive, more open to change, and more capable of solving their own problems. Empathy is not just an emotional luxury, it is one of the most powerful forces for genuine human change.

Vocabulary

Word	Part of speech	Meaning in context	Example
empathy	<i>noun</i>	The ability to feel and understand what another person feels	<i>She showed deep empathy.</i>
sympathy	<i>noun</i>	Feeling sorry for someone from a distance	<i>Sympathy is not the same as empathy.</i>
demanding	<i>adjective</i>	Requiring a lot of effort, skill, or attention	<i>Empathy is emotionally demanding.</i>
shameful	<i>adjective</i>	Causing feelings of shame or embarrassment	<i>He found it shameful to ask for help.</i>
complexity	<i>noun</i>	The state of being complicated and having many parts	<i>Hold the complexity of other people.</i>
narrative	<i>noun</i>	A story or account of events; a way of understanding	<i>Don't reduce people to a simple narrative.</i>
suspending	<i>verb</i>	Temporarily stopping or setting aside	<i>Suspending judgement is key.</i>
reassurance	<i>noun</i>	Words or actions that reduce worry or fear	<i>We often give reassurance instead of empathy.</i>
defensive	<i>adjective</i>	Feeling the need to protect yourself from criticism	<i>When threatened, people become defensive.</i>
capable	<i>adjective</i>	Having the ability to do something	<i>They are capable of solving this themselves.</i>
luxury	<i>noun</i>	Something nice but not necessary	<i>Empathy is not a luxury.</i>

reducing	<i>verb</i>	Making something smaller or simpler than it is	<i>Avoid reducing people to labels.</i>
analysis	<i>noun</i>	A detailed examination of something	<i>He responded with analysis instead of care.</i>
perspective	<i>noun</i>	A particular way of thinking about something	<i>Try to see it from their perspective.</i>
internal	<i>adjective</i>	Existing within a person's mind or feelings	<i>Everyone has a complex internal world.</i>

Word-tracking grid

Word-tracking grid, how to use it

Each time you use a word in a real conversation, tick one box (☐). Aim for 5 uses before moving on. Do not tick in advance.

Word	Part of speech	1	2	3	4	5	Uses	Example I used it
empathy	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_ /5	
sympathy	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_ /5	
demanding	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_ /5	
shameful	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_ /5	
complexity	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_ /5	
narrative	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_ /5	
suspending	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_ /5	
reassurance	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_ /5	
defensive	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_ /5	
capable	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_ /5	
luxury	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_ /5	
reducing	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_ /5	
analysis	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_ /5	
perspective	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_ /5	
internal	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_ /5	
Total							_ /75	<i>Complete → move to next unit</i>

Speaking prompts

Use these prompts as conversation starters. Try to use as many unit words as possible naturally.

1

What is the difference between empathy and sympathy in practice?

- | | |
|---|--|
| 2 | Can you remember a time when someone showed you real empathy? How did it feel? |
| 3 | What stops people from being more empathetic? |
| 4 | Do you think empathy can be learned or is it something you either have or don't? |

Grammar focus

Not just ... but, extending a claim

'Not just ... but' is used to extend a point beyond its initial scope: 'not just an emotional luxury, it is one of the most powerful forces'. This pattern adds weight to a statement.

Examples from the passage context:

- Empathy is not just a feeling, but a skill.
- Not just listening, but truly understanding.
- Not just kind, but profoundly effective.
- It's not just about words, but about presence.

Practice task:

Write 3 sentences using 'not just ... but' to make a point about communication, empathy, or human behaviour.

Write your answers here:

Review Unit 3

Recycling vocabulary from Unit 7, Unit 8, Unit 9

Mixed tracking grid

Use each word in a new sentence you write yourself. Tick a box each time you use it in conversation.

Word	1	2	3	4	5	Sentence using the word
forgiveness	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
burden	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
immune	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
releasing	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
ongoing	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
penalised	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
avoidance	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
valiantly	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
considerable	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
ambitious	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
empathy	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
shameful	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
suspending	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
capable	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
analysis	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	

Cumulative speaking challenge

Use at least 8 of the review words in a single conversation on any topic. Try to connect the words naturally, don't just list them.

Words I used:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

5. _____

6. _____

7. _____

8. _____

Self-assessment:

How naturally did you use the words?

☐ Very naturally ☐ Mostly well ☐ Needs more practice

Notes:

Unit 10 · Silence · What is not said

We live in a culture that equates productivity with noise. Every moment must be filled. Silence feels like emptiness, and emptiness feels like failure. But silence is not emptiness. It is potential.

In music, the pauses between notes are as important as the notes themselves. Without silence, there is only noise. The same is true in conversation. The best communicators are not those who speak the most, but those who know when to stop, when to allow a pause to do the work that words cannot.

Silence in conversation creates space. It allows the other person to think, to feel, to say what they had not yet found the words for. Many of the most important things in any conversation are said in the moments just after a pause.

Silence also has an interior dimension. When we are quiet, truly quiet, without our phones or music or inner narration, we begin to hear things about ourselves that we usually drown out. The question we have been avoiding. The feeling we have been suppressing. The decision we already know we need to make.

Perhaps the most radical act in a noisy world is to stop, and listen.

Vocabulary

Word	Part of speech	Meaning in context	Example
equates	<i>verb</i>	Considers two things to be the same or equal	<i>She equates silence with failure.</i>
potential	<i>noun</i>	The possibility of something developing or being achieved	<i>Silence is full of potential.</i>
pause	<i>noun</i>	A temporary stop or moment of silence	<i>Use pauses in conversation.</i>
dimension	<i>noun</i>	An aspect or feature of a situation	<i>There is an interior dimension to silence.</i>
interior	<i>adjective</i>	Existing within; relating to the inside of something	<i>Pay attention to your interior world.</i>
narration	<i>noun</i>	A spoken or written account; internal commentary	<i>Stop the inner narration.</i>
suppressing	<i>verb</i>	Preventing something from being expressed or felt	<i>She was suppressing her emotions.</i>
radical	<i>adjective</i>	Representing a major change; thorough and extreme	<i>Silence is a radical act today.</i>
emptiness	<i>noun</i>	The state of containing nothing; a feeling of having no purpose	<i>Silence is not emptiness.</i>
drown out	<i>phrasal verb</i>	To prevent from being heard by making a louder noise	<i>We drown out our own thoughts.</i>
avoiding	<i>verb</i>	Keeping away from something you don't want to face	<i>The question I've been avoiding.</i>

productive	<i>adjective</i>	Achieving a lot in a useful way	<i>Silence can be productive.</i>
interior	<i>adjective</i>	Relating to the inner mind or feelings	<i>Interior silence leads to clarity.</i>
communicators	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	People who convey information or feelings to others	<i>The best communicators know when to be silent.</i>
equate	<i>verb</i>	To consider two things to be equal or the same	<i>Don't equate silence with weakness.</i>

Word-tracking grid

Word-tracking grid, how to use it

Each time you use a word in a real conversation, tick one box (☐). Aim for 5 uses before moving on. Do not tick in advance.

Word	Part of speech	1	2	3	4	5	Uses	Example I used it
equates	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
potential	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
pause	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
dimension	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
interior	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
narration	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
suppressing	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
radical	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
emptiness	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
drown out	<i>phrasal verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
avoiding	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
productive	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
interior	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
communicators	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
equate	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
Total							_/75	Complete → move to next unit

Speaking prompts

Use these prompts as conversation starters. Try to use as many unit words as possible naturally.

1

How comfortable are you with silence, in conversation, or when you're alone?

- 2 Have you ever been in a conversation where a pause said more than words?
- 3 What do you hear when you are truly quiet?
- 4 How does the culture around you treat silence? Is it valued or avoided?

Grammar focus

Those who ... / The ones who ..., defining with relative clauses

We use 'those who' and 'the ones who' to define a group of people: 'the best communicators are those who know when to stop'. This pattern is common in analytical and philosophical writing.

Examples from the passage context:

- Those who listen well tend to be trusted.
- The ones who pause are often the most thoughtful.
- It is those who accept silence who find clarity.
- The ones who speak least often say the most.

Practice task:

Write 3 sentences using 'those who' or 'the ones who' to describe types of people or behaviours.

Write your answers here:

Unit 11 · Honesty · The uncomfortable truth

Most people value honesty in principle. But when honesty becomes inconvenient, when the truth might hurt someone, damage a relationship, or cost you something, most people choose a version of the truth that is easier to live with.

This is understandable. We are social creatures. Maintaining harmony feels important. And yet, the habit of strategic dishonesty, telling people what they want to hear, rather than what is true, has significant costs.

For the person being protected from the truth, it prevents them from growing, improving, or making decisions based on accurate information. For the person doing the protecting, it creates a quiet erosion of their own integrity, a growing gap between what they say and what they know.

The philosopher Kant argued that honesty is an absolute moral duty, that lying is wrong regardless of consequences. Most modern thinkers disagree. But what almost everyone agrees on is that a culture of consistent honesty, in which people are trusted to handle truth, tends to produce better relationships, better organisations, and better lives.

The hardest kind of honesty is self-honesty, being truthful about your own motivations, fears, and limitations. This is where most of us have the most to gain and the furthest to go.

Vocabulary

Word	Part of speech	Meaning in context	Example
inconvenient	<i>adjective</i>	Causing difficulty or effort; not easy or comfortable	<i>The truth was inconvenient.</i>
strategic	<i>adjective</i>	Planned to achieve a particular aim	<i>Strategic dishonesty is still dishonesty.</i>
erosion	<i>noun</i>	The gradual wearing away of something	<i>Lying causes an erosion of integrity.</i>
absolute	<i>adjective</i>	Total and unconditional; allowing no exceptions	<i>Kant believed honesty was an absolute duty.</i>
regardless	<i>adverb</i>	Despite everything; without considering something	<i>Honesty is right regardless of cost.</i>
consequences	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	The results or effects of an action	<i>Consider the consequences of dishonesty.</i>
motivations	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	Reasons or desires that cause someone to act	<i>Question your own motivations.</i>
limitations	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	Things that limit what you can do	<i>Know your own limitations.</i>
accurate	<i>adjective</i>	Correct; exactly right	<i>Make decisions based on accurate information.</i>
harmony	<i>noun</i>	A pleasing state of agreement or order	<i>We often sacrifice honesty for harmony.</i>
principle	<i>noun</i>	A rule or belief that guides behaviour	<i>She values honesty in principle.</i>
consistent	<i>adjective</i>	Behaving in the same way every time	<i>Consistent honesty builds trust.</i>

self-honesty	<i>noun</i>	Being truthful with yourself about your own nature	<i>Self-honesty is the hardest kind.</i>
protecting	<i>verb</i>	Keeping someone safe from something difficult	<i>Lying is not truly protecting someone.</i>
thinkers	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	People who think carefully and systematically about ideas	<i>Modern thinkers often disagree with Kant.</i>

Word-tracking grid

Word-tracking grid, how to use it

Each time you use a word in a real conversation, tick one box (☐). Aim for 5 uses before moving on. Do not tick in advance.

Word	Part of speech	1	2	3	4	5	Uses	Example I used it
inconvenient	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
strategic	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
erosion	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
absolute	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
regardless	<i>adverb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
consequences	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
motivations	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
limitations	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
accurate	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
harmony	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
principle	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
consistent	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
self-honesty	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
protecting	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
thinkers	<i>noun (pl.)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	
Total							_/75	<i>Complete → move to next unit</i>

Speaking prompts

Use these prompts as conversation starters. Try to use as many unit words as possible naturally.

1	Have you ever told someone a 'comfortable lie'? Do you regret it?
2	What is the difference between being honest and being unkind?

3 Do you find it easier to be honest with others or with yourself?

4 In what situations do you find honesty most difficult?

Grammar focus

Rather than, preference and contrast in formal register

'Rather than' indicates preference of one thing over another: 'telling people what they want to hear, rather than what is true'. In formal writing, it is often followed by -ing.

Examples from the passage context:

- Rather than avoiding the truth, face it.
- She chose honesty rather than comfort.
- Rather than suppressing your feelings, express them.
- Integrity means acting on your values rather than your fears.

Practice task:

Write 3 sentences using 'rather than' about honesty, communication, or personal values.

Write your answers here:

Unit 12 · Acceptance · Letting things be

Acceptance is not passive. It is not resignation, and it is not pretending that things are better than they are. Acceptance is the active, conscious acknowledgement of what is, without the additional suffering that comes from insisting it should be otherwise.

The Buddhist concept of dukkha describes a particular kind of suffering that comes not from pain itself, but from the resistance to pain. We burn ourselves, and then we burn ourselves again by being angry about the burn, by wishing it hadn't happened, by insisting on a version of reality where it didn't. Acceptance means stopping the second burn.

Acceptance is also frequently confused with approval. Accepting a situation does not mean you think it is good. It does not mean you won't try to change it. It means you have stopped fighting against the fact of its existence, which frees up your energy to actually deal with it.

In grief, in illness, in disappointment, in the ordinary losses that accumulate over a life, acceptance is usually the turning point. Not because it makes the pain go away, but because it allows you to be fully present with reality, and from that ground, something new can grow.

Vocabulary

Word	Part of speech	Meaning in context	Example
passive	<i>adjective</i>	Accepting what happens without trying to change it	<i>Acceptance is not passive resignation.</i>
resignation	<i>noun</i>	The acceptance of something undesirable without protest	<i>Don't confuse acceptance with resignation.</i>
acknowledgement	<i>noun</i>	Recognition that something is true or exists	<i>Acceptance begins with acknowledgement.</i>
insisting	<i>verb</i>	Demanding or maintaining firmly	<i>Stop insisting reality is different.</i>
dukkha	<i>noun</i>	Buddhist concept of suffering caused by resistance and desire	<i>Dukkha comes from resisting what is.</i>
resistance	<i>noun</i>	The refusal to accept or comply with something	<i>Resistance creates extra suffering.</i>
approval	<i>noun</i>	Agreement that something is acceptable or right	<i>Acceptance is not the same as approval.</i>
existence	<i>noun</i>	The fact of something being real	<i>Stop fighting the fact of its existence.</i>
frees up	<i>phrasal verb</i>	Makes available; releases for another purpose	<i>Acceptance frees up your energy.</i>
accumulate	<i>verb</i>	To gather or build up over time	<i>Losses accumulate over a life.</i>
turning point	<i>noun (phrase)</i>	A time when a decisive change occurs	<i>Acceptance is the turning point.</i>

ground	<i>noun</i>	A basis or foundation from which to act	<i>From that ground, something new grows.</i>
ordinary	<i>adjective</i>	Normal; not special or unusual	<i>Even ordinary losses require acceptance.</i>
conscious	<i>adjective</i>	Deliberate and aware; intentional	<i>Acceptance is a conscious choice.</i>
frequently	<i>adverb</i>	Often; many times	<i>Acceptance is frequently misunderstood.</i>

Word-tracking grid

Word-tracking grid, how to use it

Each time you use a word in a real conversation, tick one box (☐). Aim for 5 uses before moving on. Do not tick in advance.

Word	Part of speech	1	2	3	4	5	Uses	Example I used it
passive	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
resignation	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
acknowledgement	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
insisting	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
dukkha	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
resistance	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
approval	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
existence	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
frees up	<i>phrasal verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
accumulate	<i>verb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
turning point	<i>noun (phrase)</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
ground	<i>noun</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
ordinary	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
conscious	<i>adjective</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
frequently	<i>adverb</i>	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_/5	_____
Total							_/75	<i>Complete → move to next unit</i>

Speaking prompts

Use these prompts as conversation starters. Try to use as many unit words as possible naturally.

1 What is something in your life you have found hard to accept?

- 2 How is acceptance different from giving up?
- 3 Can you think of a time when accepting something made you feel freer?
- 4 Do you think Western culture values acceptance? Why or why not?

Grammar focus

It does not mean ... / It means ..., clarifying what something is and isn't

This logical structure, denying a wrong interpretation, then stating the correct one, is very effective in both speech and writing: 'It does not mean you think it is good. It means you have stopped fighting...'

Examples from the passage context:

- It doesn't mean approval. It means understanding.
- Acceptance does not mean weakness. It means clarity.
- It doesn't mean forgetting. It means releasing.
- It does not mean silence. It means choosing carefully.

Practice task:

Write 3 pairs of sentences using 'It does not mean ... It means ...' to clarify a concept you care about.

Write your answers here:

Review Unit 4

Recycling vocabulary from Unit 10, Unit 11, Unit 12

Mixed tracking grid

Use each word in a new sentence you write yourself. Tick a box each time you use it in conversation.

Word	1	2	3	4	5	Sentence using the word
equates	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
dimension	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
suppressing	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
drown out	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
interior	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
inconvenient	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
absolute	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
motivations	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
harmony	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
self-honesty	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
passive	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
insisting	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
approval	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
accumulate	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
ordinary	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	

Cumulative speaking challenge

Use at least 8 of the review words in a single conversation on any topic. Try to connect the words naturally, don't just list them.

Words I used: _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____	Self-assessment: How naturally did you use the words? ☐ Very naturally ☐ Mostly well ☐ Needs more practice Notes: _____ _____ _____
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Student's guide

How to use this book

Read to Speak is built around active vocabulary acquisition. Each unit introduces 15 target words through a meaningful passage, then guides learners to use those words in real conversation before marking them as learned. The word-tracking grid is the engine of this method.

The word-tracking method

The core principle is simple: a word is not learned until it has been used, not studied, not recognised, but genuinely used, at least 5 times in real conversation. The checkbox system makes this visible and motivating.

Using the passages

Read the passage aloud with learners before studying vocabulary. Ask comprehension questions about meaning and tone. Discuss the topic before introducing the word list, learners should engage with the ideas, not just the language.

Speaking prompts

These prompts are designed to be impossible to answer without using the unit vocabulary. Push learners beyond single-word answers. Model extended responses. Encourage learners to ask each other follow-up questions.

Grammar focus

Each grammar point is drawn from the passage itself, not added artificially. Show learners the point in context first. The practice task is intentionally open-ended, accept any grammatically correct response.

Review units

These appear after every 3 units. They recycle vocabulary from the previous 3 units. Do not introduce new vocabulary during review units. Use the self-assessment section for learner reflection.

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For self-study learners

Self-study learners should find a conversation partner, a friend, tutor, or language exchange partner, to complete the speaking components. The word-tracking grid works perfectly for solo conversation practice with a partner.

Adapting for different learners

For stronger learners, encourage use of the vocabulary across topics, not just in direct response to the prompts. For weaker learners, allow use of the word in a simpler sentence before building up.